Figure 9.6 The contract storage solution is GitHub repository in this contract testing example without Pact Broker.

Option 2, the third-party hosted Pact Broker, provides assurances around stability and removing the burden of maintaining the infrastructure. However, the third-party hosted option comes at a cost, dependent on the size of the team and the number of integrations. In section 9.3, we'll show how to register and set up a PactFlow account.

Option 3, the open source Pact Broker, offers flexibility and is free initially before factoring in maintenance and hosting costs. Pact Broker has a few deployment options for deploying within your infrastructure. Deploying within your infrastructure provides confidence around security and a sense of control. Section 9.4 of this chapter will explore the different deployment options in more detail.

To make a calculated decision on which option fits with the requirements for your project, you'll likely want to see it in action. In the next section, we'll look at option 2, as this is a great starting point for initiating a contract testing proof of concept. Option 1 is also great for those without experience with a broker or those who don't have the time to set up the infrastructure for option 3.

9.3 SaaS Pact Broker (PactFlow)

PactFlow is the chosen SaaS Pact Broker provider, as this is the original tool from the team that created Pact. PactFlow MVP was launched in 2016 (https://pactFlow.io/about/) by Matt Fellows, Beth Skurrie, and Ron Holshausen. PactFlow has evolved a lot over the years by incorporating features to support its users, from single sign-on (SSO) to Pact plugins. To publish the contracts in the other chapters, we simply set up a free version from the PactFlow website, enabling us to demo the end-to-end process of contract testing, which is exactly what people should do when running a proof of concept. However, committing to the contract testing journey isn't that simple. Using Pact Broker will probably involve others in the decision-making process, especially those who control the budget.